

Q: It's interesting to hear you say this because exactly something like this happened a few years ago. You'll recall that time when women were at the top of Indian banking with Shikha Sharma, Chanda Kochhar, and Arundhati Bhat-tacharya running three of the top banks in the country. Then the Chanda Kochhar episode happened and exactly as you said, there were men smirking, saying, oh, look, it was just a matter of time before something like this happened. Do you think that took some of the gloss off the women-breaking-the-glass-ceiling story in India?

A: I don't think so. It was, of course, unfortunate. One of the most celebrated women leaders literally falling as she did from a very, very high perch, is troubling at any time for any leader. It didn't have to be a woman but you are right that there was that additional scrutiny around it in terms of—is this about other women, too? I'm just glad that there were other competent women at the time—Arundhati [and] Shikha, among others—which prevented it from becoming an outright man/woman issue. After all, there are men who had been in similar situations, too. So, I think at the time it did take some of the sheen off women CEOs who were being celebrated as if they were better than men, which I think is always silly because at that level, it is really very individual.

I have had as many good male bosses as bad ones, and it will always be the case that there will be individuals who in their own right are fabulous human beings and great leaders; and individuals who may be smart but are not such good leaders, whether men or women. And I think we have to just take the good and the bad as it goes. You cannot typecast men and women leaders once you're at that level.

ON WOMEN FALLING

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ON CORPORATE PRACTICES

You can easily be blindsided by a management that chooses not to bring certain things out in the open. But when the regulator questions something, a board cannot ignore that. If the management has been forthright, at least we hear the bad news well before it becomes bad news in the public market. And that is the way for good managements to operate.

ON CLIMATE CHANGE

It is difficult for each small company to have a programme [to tackle climate change] for themselves. Getting them to pay for it is the answer rather than getting each to do it. The danger then is that sometimes it becomes a tick-box exercise.

Q: True, it cannot be a man versus woman issue. But on the subject, a few weeks ago I was talking to Zia Mody and she said something very interesting. She said you know Udayan, I would always work twice as hard as my male colleagues to just stand out and succeed. Did you ever feel that yourself—that you had to go the extra mile to stand out?

A: Oh, absolutely, Udayan. There's no doubt about that one. And it wasn't just Zia; I had done a book on 30 women CEOs, their voices, their stories, and pretty much every one of those women CEOs had felt that pressure of having to work twice as hard to be heard, to be understood, and to make their way forward. Don't forget that working hard doesn't just come from the office environment, but also from trying to balance all that happens at home where the social pressures of being the ideal wife, mother, daughter-in-law, daughter, all of that too weighs on women as they make their way through their careers. And, that aspect of society, the aspect which puts pressure on women to really have two huge roles—one at work, and one at home—is one that needs attention, because until society changes, women carry an unequal and uneven burden into the workplace even today.

Q: You just said something important because I always like to ask very successful women whether their success takes any kind of toll on their interpersonal relationship with their partner. Purely in a corporate sense, you were the more successful between you and your husband; did that ever put any kind of strain on your equation?

A: Udayan, never, because what I had was a husband who was extremely supportive. One who had succeeded